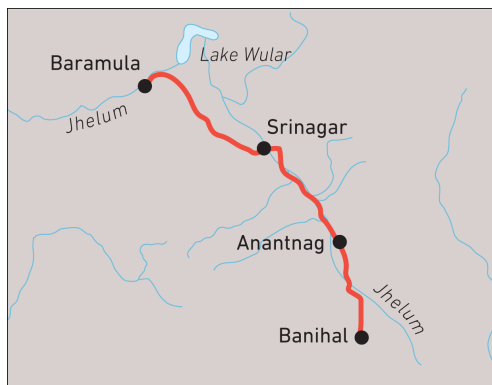

SNOWY PARADISE

74614, *Banihal–Baramulla*



Don't go by the train's rather prosaic name. The journey from Banihal to the ancient town of Baramulla in the Vale of Kashmir is far more poetic. The landscape changes dramatically through the course of the journey, which begins at Banihal and crosses the Pir Panjal range, separating Jammu from the Kashmir Valley. The DEMU (Diesel–electric Multiple Unit)

makes its way past the Jammu hills through the Pir Panjal railway tunnel, which at over 11 km is the longest in India. A little over nine minutes later, it emerges into the Kashmir Valley, with its rolling hills, Chir pines, and snow-clad mountains. En route, the train travels 110 km in two and-a half hours through Anantnag, Srinagar, Kashmir's capital, and finally Baramulla on the banks of the Jhelum River. It is best to make the trip during winter when the region is snowbound or after the monsoon in August to experience the breathtaking landscape in its glory.